But the anger of such men did not die with them. Centuries later, Jawaharlal Nehru wrote of how the Muslim League ‘kept aloof’ from the fourth-centenary celebrations of Akbar’s birth.

It wasn’t only orthodox Muslim opinion that sided against Akbar, however. The Jesuit Fathers of the third mission, led by Father Xavier, believed that God himself was raining punishments upon the heretical emperor: the death of his son, Murad; then a great fire in Lahore that ravaged the palace – so much so, it was said, that ‘gold, silver, and other metals melted . . . [and] ran down the streets like streams of water’.[6]

Colonial and nationalist historians might have written with modern detachment of Akbar’s heterodoxy, but picked other quarrels with the emperor, condemning his appetite for power, or accusing him of duplicity. Thus, by 1922, J.S. Hoyland and S.N. Banerjee, writing their introduction to Monserrate’s memoirs and comparing Akbar unfavourably with the Mauryan emperor Ashoka, declared that ‘modern researches’ had undone the idea of Akbar as an ideal ‘philosopher-king’: ‘His character with its mixture of ambition and cunning has now been laid bare.’

Among nationalist historians, Akbar and Ashoka may have been two ‘greats’ who united the diversity of newly independent India, but not all historians of this school were able to fully disguise an instinctive suspicion of the Muslim ruler. R.C. Majumdar damns him by exception – the only good man in a dynasty of kings ‘notorious for their religious bigotry’.[7]

A.L. Srivastava’s censure is more a slip of the pen. In a biography that credits Akbar with establishing ‘national Indian’ schools of every kind, from music to architecture, Srivastava also describes the emperor, in his youth, as a ‘good, though tolerant, Muslim’ – as if the two qualities contradict each other quite naturally.[8]

And now, a century later, another troop of adversaries rallies against Akbar, politicians, columnists and makers of memes, leaders and foot soldiers of Hindutva straining to strip Akbar of his usual suffix, ‘the great’, and hand it to a more deserving – or, let us say, more Hindu – king, like Hemu or

Rana Pratap.

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